



unesco

Mahatma Gandhi Institute of
Education for Peace and
Sustainable Development

Skill 1: Calming the Body and Mind

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Discuss the importance of Body literacy and recognize the emotional state in a given situation
- Identify the right vocabulary to name the different sensations in the body
- Define the resilient zone and its connection to emotional regulation
- Recognize when you are out of the resilience zone
- Discuss the role and importance of the parasympathetic nervous system
- Use tools for better emotional regulation

Introduction

Imagine you're about to go on a fun weekend road trip. Your bags are packed, your fuel tank is full, and you've got your road trip playlist ready. You're excited and ready to hit the road. There's some traffic, but you're not worried. You'll soon be speeding through the highway.

But then, thirty minutes into your drive, you see smoke coming from your car/bike engine. You have to slow down and stop. You start to regret not getting your car serviced last week. To make things worse, the driver behind you starts honking, and you get angry. You shout back, feeling annoyed at the driver, your car, and most of all, yourself.

Does this sound familiar? Our minds and bodies are like that car engine – they need regular care and attention. The first step to improving your life and your relationships is to focus on your own well-being. You can do this by developing:

- Inner calm
- Self-control
- Emotional intelligence
- Self-compassion

These skills help you build a strong foundation for being kinder to others and creating a more peaceful society. It might seem complicated, but don't worry. In this course, we'll take it one step at a time.

Let's start with skill 1: Calming Body and Mind, learning how to achieve a greater degree of inner calm.

The nervous system reacts to external and internal stimuli very quickly. Difficult emotions or thoughts usually begin as bodily sensations and are often leading indicators of stress, anxiety, fear and depression as well as states of joy, calm and clarity. Your body and mind are deeply connected and anything you experience in one will immediately and automatically affect the other.

In this module, we will:

1. Learn to recognize the various sensations in the body, therefore developing better body literacy
2. Explore the resilient zone and its connection to emotional regulation
3. Learn to use tools like tracking, grounding and resourcing

To get started, simply take your time going through this module. Be sure to explore the practices and techniques we've outlined to help you work towards achieving a calm, yet alert state of mind. Mastering this skill will also help pave the way for the other skills in this course, such as developing mindfulness, compassion, gratitude, and common humanity.

So, let's get started, shall we?

Sensation Words

Calming our body and mind starts with observing the various sensations in our body. Sensation words refer to the language of our autonomic nervous system that registers safety and regulates our organs accordingly. While emotion words help us express how we are feeling, body sensations can provide additional information.

Body literacy is the ability to understand and interpret these sensations in our bodies. It involves recognizing and responding to physical signals and cues, which helps in identifying emotional states and maintaining overall well-being.

Developing body literacy can improve your self-awareness and enhance your ability to manage emotions effectively. By paying attention to your body's signals, you can cultivate a greater degree of inner calm, self-control, emotional intelligence, and self-compassion.

Resilient Zone

The sensations in our body are an indicator of whether we are in or out of our resilient zone. According to Elaine Miller, of the Trauma Research Institute, a resilient zone is defined as, a state of equilibrium where we feel balanced and capable of dealing with stressful or traumatic experiences. It doesn't stop us from experiencing emotions such as anger or sadness, but it may help us retain control over our thoughts and actions in such moments.

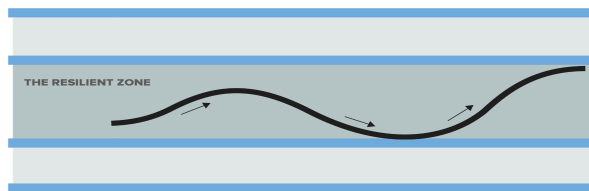
Being in the resilient zone is closely linked to emotional regulation. When we are in our resilient zone, we can handle stress and bounce back from challenges more effectively. This state helps us manage our emotions, so we don't overreact to situations and can stay calm and focused.

In everyday life, being in the resilient zone might look like staying calm during a tough exam, not losing your temper in a heated argument, or managing anxiety before a big presentation. When we are out of our resilient zone, we might feel overwhelmed/nervous, anxious, or overly stressed, and it becomes harder to think clearly and make good decisions.

Developing body literacy and understanding our resilient zone can greatly enhance our emotional regulation. By paying attention to the sensations in our body, we can notice early signs of stress/anxiety and take steps to return to our resilient zone.

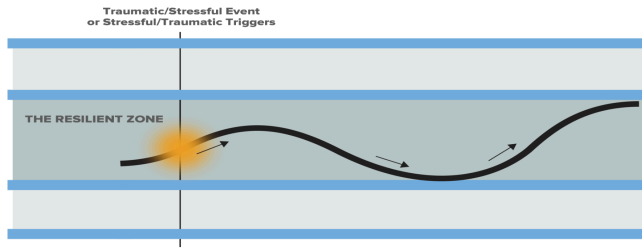
In the next section, we will discuss the resilience zone in detail and what happens when we are out of the resilience zone.

Resilient Zone

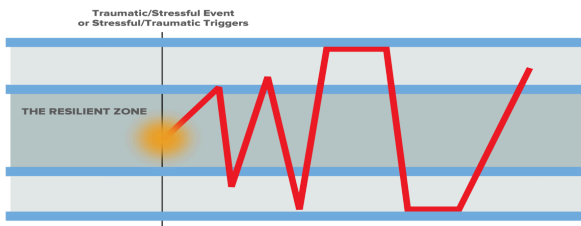


Based on the Community Resiliency Model, the Trauma Resource Institute

As shown in the wave depiction, the Resilient Zone is where we experience the full range of emotions while staying balanced and in control. In this zone, we are calm, strong, and able to make our best decisions. It's not necessarily our "happy place" because we can still feel sadness but remain resilient and calm. We can call this the "okay zone." This zone allows us to respond to challenges with a clear mind and stable emotions.



Do we always stay in our resilient zone? Not really. We all face various stressful situations every day, and when stressed, our nervous system can be thrown out of balance, causing us to leave our resilient zone. For example, a tough exam, an argument with a friend, or even a loud noise can disrupt our inner balance.



It is natural to be bumped out of the Resilient Zone. The graphic demonstrates the natural rhythm of the nervous system (the black line) and shows how a trigger or a traumatic/stressful event (represented by the orange thunderbolt) can cause the nervous system to get bumped out of the Resilient Zone (the red line). These triggers can be anything from a sudden loud noise to a reminder of a past trauma.

For some of us, especially due to stressful or traumatic experiences, leaving the Resilient Zone may happen regularly. When out of this zone, we might feel constantly on edge ("stuck on high"), where everything seems to irritate us and we can't relax. Or, we might feel depressed and tired ("stuck on low"), where we lack energy and motivation. Sometimes, it can feel like being on a roller coaster, fluctuating between these extremes, making it hard to maintain a sense of normalcy/balance.

Dysregulation can be triggered by almost anything that reminds a person of a traumatic or stressful event, such as a smell, sight, sound, touch, or body position. This can happen even without our conscious awareness. For instance, a particular song might bring back memories of a difficult time, causing an emotional reaction.

Understanding the Resilient Zone and how to maintain it is crucial for emotional regulation and overall well-being. By developing body literacy, we can recognize when we are out of our

resilient zone and take steps to return to it. This involves paying attention to our body's signals and using techniques that we will discuss later in this module.

Sympathetic and Parasympathetic Nervous System

Our nervous system has two main parts: an alerting, stressed-out part and a calming, relaxing part. When we are stressed or when our brain perceives danger, our sympathetic nervous system gets activated to respond to threats. This leads to the fight, flight, or freeze response, where our heartbeat increases and blood flow to our limbs prepares us for action.

On the other hand, our body also has the capacity to calm us down after a stressful incident through the parasympathetic nervous system. This system helps us relax and recover. The part of our nervous system that we use the most becomes the strongest, so it's important to intentionally train our bodies to strengthen the parasympathetic response. Without this, our nervous system can become unhealthy, constantly stuck in a state of stress.

A healthy nervous system can use both the activating response and the calming response effectively. An unhealthy nervous system sees threats everywhere and gets stuck in a state of hyper-arousal (always on edge) or hypo-arousal (feeling numb and disconnected).

Spending more time in the calm state, or the resilient zone, is essential for our well-being. The good news is that we can influence which part of our nervous system is activated and train ourselves to strengthen the parasympathetic nervous system. This helps us stay in the resilient zone for longer periods.

To help us achieve this, we can practice various exercises. The next section introduces three powerful tools that can assist us when we are knocked out of the resilient zone: tracking, grounding, and resourcing.

These tools help us become more aware of our body's signals, anchor ourselves in the present moment, and draw on positive resources to manage stress effectively.

Tracking

Tracking involves noticing or paying attention to what is happening inside your body at the present moment. It helps you determine if the sensation is pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. By sitting or staying with sensations that are pleasant or neutral, you can build a stronger connection to your body's signals and foster resilience.

Tracking activity

Activity Prep: Download the sensation words list [here](#), before the activity

1. Sit in a comfortable position
2. Once you are ready, place the palms of your hands together and keep rubbing them back and forth

3. Now, observe what you are experiencing on the inside of your body, can you identify the pleasant or neutral sensations in your body?
4. See if you can identify sensations rather than emotions or thoughts
5. Refer to the sensation words list you downloaded before this activity. Make a note of the different sensations you are experiencing in your journal.

By practicing tracking, you enhance your ability to stay in the present moment and develop a deeper awareness of your body's responses. This can significantly improve your emotional regulation and overall well-being.

Grounding

Grounding involves noticing the direct contact of an object with your body that provides a sense of support and stability. When the nervous system is dysregulated, it can be helpful to focus on a part of the body that feels grounded or supported. For example, if you are sitting in a chair and your feet feel firm and supported on the ground, you can notice this sensation and sit with it for a few moments.

Grounding can be particularly useful during moments of high stress, anxiety, or when you feel overwhelmed. It helps bring your attention back to the present moment, creating a sense of stability and calm.

Grounding Practice

- Find a position that is most comfortable for you. You could sit on a chair, a cushion on the floor, or even stand leaning against a wall.
- Bring your attention to the part of your body that is in contact with another object. It could be your back against the chair or the wall, your feet on the floor, or your hands on your lap.
- As you do this, notice the various sensations in your body. Focus on the pleasant or neutral sensations and rest your attention there.
- Continue this for as long as you feel comfortable, allowing your body to experience a sense of support and stability.

Grounding helps to bring your attention to the present moment and can create a feeling of being anchored and secure.

You can use grounding in any situation, especially when you are in a crowded market, during exams, interviews, or meetings. To ground yourself, simply bring your attention to a part of your body that is in contact with an object. It could be the chair you are sitting on, a pen you are holding, a piece of jewelry you are wearing, or anything around you at that moment.

Resourcing

A Resource is any person, place, thing, memory, or part of yourself that makes you feel calm, pleasant, peaceful, strong, or resilient. Resources can be unique to each of us, and we can have multiple resources. To practice resourcing, one brings the resource to mind as vividly as possible. This practice helps us feel supported and can significantly enhance our resilience and emotional regulation.

Build your own resource

- Think of a resource – it could be a place you loved visiting in the past, a person you like the most, or even an activity you enjoy doing.
- Now, picture it in vivid detail/Now, imagine it clearly. Try to include as many of your senses as appropriate/ Use as many senses as you can. (colors, textures, sounds, tastes, etc.).
- As you do this, notice the various sensations in your body. Rest your attention on the pleasant or neutral sensations/ Focus on the pleasant or neutral sensations.
- Make a note of the sensations you notice in your journal/ Write down the sensations you notice in your journal.

By visualizing and engaging with your resource, you can create a sense of calm and stability that helps you manage stress and maintain emotional balance.

You could use resourcing in situations where you are feeling low on energy/motivation, before a stressful event, or after a difficult experience.